Reading Skills

Source: Technical Communication: Principles and Practice (Third edition) by Meenakshi Raman & Sangeeta Sharma

Introduction

"Reading is to mind what exercise is to body."

-------Richard Steele

Reading is one of the most important activities any successful student does in any course of study. It is important to note that reading is an active process; you need to apply strategies that will enable you make sense of what you read.

Techniques for good comprehension skills:

A good way of getting started on developing your reading skills is to think about how you read a text or passage. There are several techniques that you can use.

Skimming

Skimming is used to quickly gather the most important, or 'gist'
It is not essential to understand each word when skimming. Skimiming is covering the text to get some of the main ideas and a general overview of the material. You don't read for details at this point:

Here is how you skim a chapter:

Read the first paragraph of the chapter line by line.

Next, read all the bold print headings starting at the beginning.

Read the first sentence of every paragraph.

Study any pictures, graphs, charts, and maps.

Finally, read the last paragraph of the chapter.

As you skim, you could write down the main ideas and develop a chapter outline.

Examples of Skimming:

The Newspaper (quickly to get the general news of the day)

Magazines (quickly to discover which articles you would like to read in more detail)

Business and Travel Brochures (quickly to get informed)

2. Scanning

After having skimmed the text, you can study it in more detail - looking for specific information that you are interested in. This is called scanning.

The technique of scanning is a useful one if you want to get an overview of the text you are reading as a whole- its shape, the focus of each section, the topics or key issues that are dealt with, and so on. In order to scan a piece of text you might look for subheadings or identify key words and phrases which give you clues about its focus. Another useful method is to read the first sentence or two of each paragraph in order to get the general gist of the discussion and the way that it progresses.

Examples of Scanning

-The "What's on TV" section of your newspaper.
-A telephone number in the directory
-A horoscope guide

3. Non-verbal signals

The meaning of the text is not only conveyed by means of words. A text also contains non-verbal signs. Non verbal signs may include certain style features such as bold font, CAPITAL FONTS, italics, etc. these words are used to high light, emphasize, point out something.

4. Structure of the text

Most text starts with a title or sub title. After that comes the introduction and the body, followed by a conclusion or summary. An important aspect of reading is prediction. The better you can predict what you are going to read, the. faster and more effective you will read. It also includes structure of paragraphs which includes opening segment of a paragraph, middle and ending part of the paragraph. In many well written texts a reader can easily get full idea about the paragraphs by just reading opening or topic sentence of the paragraph.

5. Punctuation

Punctuation is partly based on grammar. For example, commas are often used to separate clauses. Punctuation marks also indicate how the author wants you to interpret a piece of text.

6. Author's viewpoint (inference)

In reading a text you make inferences or assumptions about the position of the author. Is the author neutral or does he/she have an opinion? Authors do so by adding certain phrases or by adding a value to a word.

7. Reader anticipation: Determining the meaning of words

As a reader you may not know the meaning of every word. One must be able to sense the contextual meaning of a given word in such a situation.

8. Summarizing

Summarizing to remember the essential contents of the text is also very important. this can be done by adopting the following steps:

-Familarize yourself with the material

-Select important information

-Paraphrase the information

-Insert links between sentences and paragraphs

-Adjust the length of the summary

9. Preparing for typical reading comprehension questions

Questions based on the entire passage

Questions based on sections of the passage

Questions based on particular words or sentences

Knowing this helps one focus better on these aspects.